

Treatise on Good Works

The Fourth Commandment

Martin Luther made the teaching of the Bible about good works much more clear to the average Christian. He teaches that good works are commanded by God but that many Christians misunderstand what they really are.

"Thou shalt honor thy father and thy mother."

From this Commandment we learn that **after the excellent works of the first three Commandments there are no better works than to obey and serve all those who are set over us as superiors**. For this reason also **disobedience is a greater sin than murder, unchastity, theft and dishonesty**, and all that these may include. For we can in no better way learn how to distinguish between greater and lesser sins than by noting the order of the Commandments of God, although there are distinctions also within the works of each Commandment. For who does not know **that to curse is a greater sin than to be angry**, to strike than to curse, to strike father and mother more than to strike any one else? **Thus these seven Commandments teach us how we are to exercise ourselves in good works toward men, and first of all toward our superiors.**

- When should parents be disobeyed?
- How does the command to honor our parents show us how to show our love for Christ?

The **first work** is that we **honor our own father and mother**. And this honor consists not only in respectful demeanor, but in this: that we **obey** them, look up to, **esteem and heed their words** and example, accept what they say, **keep silent and endure their treatment of us, so long as it is not contrary to the first three Commandments**; in addition, **when they need it, that we provide them with food, clothing and shelter**. For not for nothing has He said: "Thou shalt honor them"; He does not say: "Thou shalt love them," although this also must be done. But honor is higher than mere love and includes a certain fear, which unites with love, and causes a man to fear offending them more than he fears the punishment. Just as there is fear in the honor we pay a sanctuary, and yet we do not flee from it as from a punishment, but draw near to it all the more. Such a fear mingled with love is the true honor; the other fear without any love is that which we have toward things which we despise or flee from, as we fear the hangman or punishment. There is no honor in that, for it is a fear without all love, nay, fear that has with it hatred and enmity. Of this we have a proverb of St. Jerome: What we fear, that we also hate. With such a fear God does not wish to be feared or honored, nor to have us honor our parents; but with the first, which is mingled with love and confidence.

- When should parents be disobeyed?
- When should parents be cared for?
- How is respect to be shown to parents?
- What does this have to do with faith in Christ?

This plague [of breaking the commandment] is so common that instances of the first form of dishonoring are very seldom seen. This is due to the fact **that the parents are blinded, and neither know nor honor God according to the first three Commandments**; hence also they cannot see what the children lack, and how they ought to teach and train them. For this reason **they train them for worldly honors, pleasure and possessions**, that they may by all means please men and reach high positions: this the children like, and they obey very gladly without gainsaying.

Thus God's Commandment secretly comes to naught while all seems good, and that is fulfilled which is written in the Prophets Isaiah and Jeremiah, that the children are destroyed by their own parents, and they do like the king Manasseh, who sacrificed his own son to the idol Moloch and burned him, II. Kings xxi. What else is it but to sacrifice one's own child to the idol and to burn it, when parents train their children more in the way of the world than in the way of

God? let them go their way, and be burned up in worldly pleasure, love, enjoyment, possessions and honor, but let God's love and honor and the desire of eternal blessings be quenched in them?

O how perilous it is to be a father or a mother, where flesh and blood are supreme! For, truly, **the knowledge and fulfilment of the first three and the last six Commandments depends altogether upon this Commandment**; since parents are commanded to teach them to their children, **as Psalm lxxviii. says, "How strictly has He commanded our fathers, that they should make known God's Commandments to their children, that the generation to come might know them and declare them to their children's children."** This also is the reason why God bids us honor our parents, that is, to love them with fear; for that other love is without fear, therefore it is more dishonor than honor.

- How does faith in God play a major part in obeying this commandment?
- What is God's plan for the first four commandments? How should they work together?

VII. The **second work of this Commandment** is to **honor and obey the spiritual mother, the holy Christian Church**, the spiritual power, so that we conform to what she commands, forbids, appoints, orders, binds and looses, and honor, fear and love the spiritual authority as we honor, love and fear our natural parents, and yield to it in all things which are not contrary to the first three Commandments.

Now with regard to this work, things are almost worse than with regard to the first. The spiritual authority **should punish sin with the ban and with laws, and constrain its spiritual children to be good**, in order that they might have reason to do this work and to exercise themselves in obeying and honoring it. Such zeal one does not see now; they act toward their subjects like the mothers who forsake their children and run after their lovers, as **Hosea ii. says; they do not preach, they do not teach, they do not hinder, they do not punish, and there is no spiritual government at all left in Christendom.**

- How can we obey the authority of the church?
- Obviously, Luther didn't always obey the rules of the church. Why? Was he inconsistent?

XII. The **third work of this Commandment** is to **obey the temporal authority**, as Paul teaches, **Romans xiii**, and **Titus iii**, and St. Peter, **I. Peter ii: "Submit yourselves to the king as supreme, and to the princes as his ambassadors, and to all the ordinances of the worldly power."** But it is the work of the temporal power to protect its subjects, and to punish thievery, robbery, and adultery, as St. Paul says, **Romans xiii: "It beareth not the sword in vain; it serves God with it, to the terror of evil doers, and to the protection of the good."**

Here **men sin in two ways. First, if they lie to the government**, deceive it, and are disloyal, neither obey nor do as it has ordered and commanded, whether with their bodies or their possessions. For even if the government does injustice, as the King of Babylon did to the people of Israel, yet God would have it obeyed, without treachery and deception. **Secondly, when men speak evil of the government and curse it**, and when a man cannot revenge himself and abuses the government with grumbling and evil words, publicly or secretly.

In all this we are to regard that which St. **Peter bids us regard, namely, that its power, whether it do right or wrong, cannot harm the soul, but only the body and property**; unless indeed it should try openly to compel us to do wrong against God or men; as in former days when the magistrates were not yet Christians, and as the Turk is now said to do. For to suffer wrong destroys no one's soul, nay, it improves the soul, although it inflicts loss upon the body and property; but to do wrong, that destroys the soul, although it should gain all the world's wealth.

- When should we respect the authority of the government?
- When should we consider obedience to human authority is wrong?
- If we disobey the government, what should we expect to happen? Should we accept that quietly?
- As believers, why should we not live in fear of what the government can do to us?